ENGLISH B2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Gradable and non-gradable adjectives

Combine degree adverbs with gradable adjectives and absolute intensifiers with extreme or classifying adjectives. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use gradable and non-gradable adjectives to scale descriptions naturally and avoid mismatches such as very impossible or absolutely tired while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Combine degree adverbs with gradable adjectives and absolute intensifiers with extreme or classifying adjectives.

MODEL

The first draft was fairly good, but the final version was absolutely outstanding.

very/fairly + gradable | absolutely/completely + extreme or absolute adjective

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

Outcome 1 Recognise the main gradable and non-gradable adjectives patterns in authentic contexts.	Outcome 2 Choose a form that accurately expresses scale descriptions naturally and avoid mismatches such as very impossible or absolutely tired.
Outcome 3 Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.	Outcome 4 Use the structure appropriately in reviews, descriptions, evaluation and persuasive writing.

Build meaning before form

Combine degree adverbs with gradable adjectives and absolute intensifiers with extreme or classifying adjectives.

What gradable and non-gradable adjectives communicates

Combine degree adverbs with gradable adjectives and absolute intensifiers with extreme or classifying adjectives.

The central purpose is to scale descriptions naturally and avoid mismatches such as very impossible or absolutely tired. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The initial estimate was slightly inaccurate.	a quality placed at a point on a scale
The final performance was absolutely outstanding.	an already intensified adjective presented categorically
The archive is virtually empty.	an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: very/fairly + gradable | absolutely/completely + extreme or absolute adjective. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “The first draft was fairly good, but the final version was absolutely outstanding.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Gradable quality	very/fairly/slightly + gradable adjective	The initial estimate was slightly inaccurate.
Extreme quality	absolutely/really + extreme adjective	The final performance was absolutely outstanding.
Absolute state	completely/virtually + absolute adjective	The archive is virtually empty.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a quality placed at a point on a scale	Gradable quality
an already intensified adjective presented categorically	Extreme quality
an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation	Absolute state

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in reviews, descriptions, evaluation and persuasive writing. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03	04
very/fairly	gradable	absolutely/completely	extreme or absolute adjective

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: scale descriptions naturally and avoid mismatches such as very impossible or absolutely tired.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits reviews, descriptions, evaluation and persuasive writing.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Gradable quality	very/fairly/slightly + gradable adjective	The initial estimate was slightly inaccurate.
Extreme quality	absolutely/really + extreme adjective	The final performance was absolutely outstanding.
Absolute state	completely/virtually + absolute adjective	The archive is virtually empty.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The initial estimate was slightly inaccurate.	a quality placed at a point on a scale
The final performance was absolutely outstanding.	an already intensified adjective presented categorically
The archive is virtually empty.	an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use absolutely with every ordinary gradable adjective.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Avoid very with conventional extreme adjectives when a natural intensifier is expected.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not treat an absolute adjective as freely gradable in every context.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a quality placed at a point on a scale?

OPTIONS The initial estimate was slightly inaccurate. · The final performance was absolutely outstanding. · The archive is virtually empty.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an already intensified adjective presented categorically?

OPTIONS The final performance was absolutely outstanding. · The archive is virtually empty. · The initial estimate was slightly inaccurate.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation?

OPTIONS The archive is virtually empty. · The initial estimate was slightly inaccurate. · The final performance was absolutely outstanding.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The initial estimate was slightly inaccurate.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a quality placed at a point on a scale · an already intensified adjective presented categorically · an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “The final performance was absolutely outstanding.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an already intensified adjective presented categorically · an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation · a quality placed at a point on a scale

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “The archive is virtually empty.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation · a quality placed at a point on a scale · an already intensified adjective presented categorically

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"The initial estimate was slightly inaccurate." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Gradable quality / Extreme quality / Absolute state · Gap 2: a quality placed at a point on a scale / an already intensified adjective presented categorically / an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"The final performance was absolutely outstanding." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Extreme quality / Absolute state / Gradable quality · Gap 2: an already intensified adjective presented categorically / an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation / a quality placed at a point on a scale

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"The archive is virtually empty." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Absolute state / Gradable quality / Extreme quality · Gap 2: an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation / a quality placed at a point on a scale / an already intensified adjective presented categorically

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a quality placed at a point on a scale: _____. Choose the model that expresses an already intensified adjective presented categorically: _____. Choose the model that expresses an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation: _____. Choose the model built with very/fairly/slightly + gradable adjective: _____. Choose the model built with absolutely/really + extreme adjective: _____. Choose the model built with completely/virtually + absolute adjective: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

The archive is virtually empty. · The final performance was absolutely outstanding. · The initial estimate was slightly inaccurate.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

04 · PRACTICE STAGE

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The initial estimate was _____. The final performance was _____. The archive is _____. State the full structural pattern for Gradable quality: _____. State the full structural pattern for Extreme quality: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The estimate was inaccurate to a small degree.” using the Gradable quality pattern to express a quality placed at a point on a scale.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The performance was exceptionally good.” using the Extreme quality pattern to express an already intensified adjective presented categorically.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “Almost nothing remains in the archive.” using the Absolute state pattern to express an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The estimate was inaccurate to a small degree.” using the Gradable quality pattern to express a quality placed at a point on a scale.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Gradable quality to express a quality placed at a point on a scale, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Extreme quality to express an already intensified adjective presented categorically, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Absolute state to express an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____

R5 · REVIEW FOCUS

Apply this decision to a new example, then justify it: Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: scale descriptions naturally and avoid mismatches such as very impossible or absolutely tired..

_____
_____

R6 · REVIEW FOCUS

Apply this decision to a new example, then justify it: Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns..

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The initial estimate was slightly inaccurate.

Gradable quality is the best match because a quality placed at a point on a scale.

A2

The final performance was absolutely outstanding.

Extreme quality is the best match because an already intensified adjective presented categorically.

A3

The archive is virtually empty.

Absolute state is the best match because an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation.

A4

a quality placed at a point on a scale

The Gradable quality pattern communicates a quality placed at a point on a scale.

A5

an already intensified adjective presented categorically

The Extreme quality pattern communicates an already intensified adjective presented categorically.

A6

an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation

The Absolute state pattern communicates an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Gradable quality / a quality placed at a point on a scale

The structure belongs to the Gradable quality pattern. Its communicative purpose is a quality placed at a point on a scale.

B2

Extreme quality / an already intensified adjective presented categorically

The structure belongs to the Extreme quality pattern. Its communicative purpose is an already intensified adjective presented categorically.

B3

Absolute state / an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation

The structure belongs to the Absolute state pattern. Its communicative purpose is an absolute category modified for completeness or approximation.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The initial estimate was slightly inaccurate.

Gradable quality: very/fairly/slightly + gradable adjective.

C2

The final performance was absolutely outstanding.

Extreme quality: absolutely/really + extreme adjective.

C3

The archive is virtually empty.

Absolute state: completely/virtually + absolute adjective.

C4

The initial estimate was slightly inaccurate.

Gradable quality: very/fairly/slightly + gradable adjective.

C5

The final performance was absolutely outstanding.

Extreme quality: absolutely/really + extreme adjective.

C6

The archive is virtually empty.

Absolute state: completely/virtually + absolute adjective.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

slightly inaccurate

Gradable quality requires “slightly inaccurate” in this model. very/fairly/slightly + gradable adjective.

D2

absolutely outstanding

Extreme quality requires “absolutely outstanding” in this model. absolutely/really + extreme adjective.

D3

virtually empty

Absolute state requires “virtually empty” in this model. completely/virtually + absolute adjective.

D4

very/fairly/slightly + gradable adjective

Gradable quality is built as very/fairly/slightly + gradable adjective.

D5

absolutely/really + extreme adjective

Extreme quality is built as absolutely/really + extreme adjective.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The initial estimate was slightly inaccurate.

very/fairly/slightly + gradable adjective. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended gradable quality effect.

E2

The final performance was absolutely outstanding.

absolutely/really + extreme adjective. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended extreme quality effect.

E3

The archive is virtually empty.

completely/virtually + absolute adjective. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended absolute state effect.

E4

The initial estimate was slightly inaccurate.

very/fairly/slightly + gradable adjective. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended gradable quality effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The initial estimate was slightly inaccurate. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses very/fairly/slightly + gradable adjective accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

The final performance was absolutely outstanding. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses absolutely/really + extreme adjective accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

The archive is virtually empty. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses completely/virtually + absolute adjective accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

07 · FEEDBACK

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

WELEARN STUDY SEQUENCE

01	02	03	04
complete guide	exercise workbook	answer key	retrieval review

RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.